



NATIONAL COUNCIL FOR INNOVATION & ENTREPRENEURSHIP (NCIE) INDIA

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Framework

Section 135 Compliance, Collegiate Skilling & Incubation Grants

Companies Act Section 135-compliant CSR engagement guidelines for collegiate skilling, incubation lab infrastructure grants (Rs. 20L - 50L), startup seed funds, project budgeting, and impact audit standards.

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA MINISTERIAL COORDINATION & ALIGNMENT

MSDE

Skill Development &
Entrepreneurship

MSME

Micro, Small &
Medium Enterprises

MeitY

Electronics &
Information Technology

MCA

Ministry of
Corporate Affairs

Document ID: NCIE/DOC/2026/CSR-10 | Edition: 2026 Master Edition | National Vision: Viksit Bharat @2047 Framework

SUPPORTING NATIONAL INITIATIVES & STRATEGIC ALLIANCES



NCIE CSR PARTNERSHIP FRAMEWORK

National Council for Innovation & Entrepreneurship (NCIE)

Framework Area: Corporate Social Responsibility, Institutional Development & Social Impact

Applicable To: Eligible Companies, CSR Foundations, Corporate Trusts, Educational Institutions, Innovation Ecosystem Partners and Other Eligible Stakeholders

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1. INTRODUCTION

The **NCIE CSR Partnership Framework** establishes a structured mechanism for developing and managing Corporate Social Responsibility partnerships in areas relevant to NCIE's organisational mandate, including **education, innovation, entrepreneurship, skill development, technology, youth empowerment, institutional capacity building and social-impact development.**

The framework is intended to facilitate collaboration among **corporates, CSR foundations, educational institutions, innovation ecosystems, industry partners and other eligible stakeholders** for the design and implementation of measurable, sustainable and outcome-oriented initiatives.

CSR partnerships shall be undertaken in accordance with **applicable legal provisions, CSR policies of the concerned company, project eligibility, due diligence requirements, approved project documents and formal agreements.**

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2. VISION

To build a responsible and outcome-oriented CSR ecosystem that mobilises corporate expertise, resources, technology and institutional partnerships to strengthen innovation, entrepreneurship, skills, education and youth development.

3. OBJECTIVES

The NCIE CSR Partnership Framework aims to:

- Develop structured CSR partnerships.
- Support education and student development.
- Promote innovation and entrepreneurship.
- Strengthen youth skills and employability capabilities.
- Support AI, digital and emerging technology programmes.
- Strengthen institutional innovation ecosystems.
- Facilitate innovation and incubation infrastructure.
- Encourage student innovation and startup development.
- Promote measurable social-impact programmes.
- Strengthen collaboration between corporates and educational institutions.
- Facilitate sustainable and scalable CSR-supported interventions.

4. CSR PARTNERSHIP PRINCIPLES

NCIE CSR partnerships shall be guided by:

Compliance

Programmes shall be undertaken subject to applicable CSR requirements and corporate approvals.

Transparency

Project objectives, budgets, responsibilities and reporting requirements should be clearly documented.

Accountability

Resources should be utilised for approved programme purposes.

Need-Based Planning

Projects should respond to identifiable beneficiary or institutional needs.

Measurable Outcomes

CSR interventions should have defined outputs, outcomes and impact indicators.

Sustainability

Projects should seek long-term institutional or beneficiary value.

Inclusiveness

Programmes may seek to improve participation among eligible beneficiaries across different social and geographic contexts.

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5. PRIORITY CSR THEMATIC AREAS

Subject to applicable CSR eligibility, NCIE may develop programmes across the following areas:

Education & Student Development

- Educational support
- Scholarships
- Student development
- Career readiness
- Digital learning
- Mentorship

Innovation

- Student innovation
- Innovation challenges
- Hackathons
- Prototype development
- Proof-of-concept support
- Innovation laboratories

Entrepreneurship

- Entrepreneurship development

- Business-model training
- Startup orientation
- Student enterprise development
- Startup validation
- Mentorship

Skill Development

- Digital skills
- Artificial Intelligence
- Emerging technologies
- Employability skills
- Professional development
- Entrepreneurship skills

Institutional Capacity Building

- Innovation centres
- Incubation centres
- Entrepreneurship Development Cells
- Digital infrastructure
- Faculty development
- Institutional innovation programmes

Youth Empowerment

- Leadership development
- Career awareness
- Professional skills
- Innovation leadership
- Entrepreneurship orientation

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6. CSR PARTNER CATEGORIES

NCIE may engage with eligible:

- Companies
- Corporate groups
- CSR foundations

- Corporate trusts
- Corporate social-impact organisations
- Industry organisations
- Other eligible CSR contributors

The eligibility and nature of the CSR contribution shall be determined by the concerned corporate organisation in accordance with applicable requirements.

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7. CSR PROJECT DEVELOPMENT PROCESS

CSR projects may be developed through the following process:

NEED IDENTIFICATION



BENEFICIARY / INSTITUTION ASSESSMENT



CSR PRIORITY MAPPING



PROJECT CONCEPT NOTE



DETAILED PROJECT PROPOSAL



BUDGET & IMPLEMENTATION PLAN



CORPORATE DUE DILIGENCE



CSR REVIEW & APPROVAL



AGREEMENT / SANCTION



IMPLEMENTATION



MONITORING & REPORTING



IMPACT ASSESSMENT

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8. CSR PROJECT PROPOSAL COMPONENTS

A CSR project proposal may include:

- Project background
- Need assessment
- Objectives
- Target beneficiaries
- Geographic coverage
- Programme activities
- Implementation methodology
- Timeline
- Budget
- Human-resource requirements
- Monitoring indicators
- Output indicators
- Outcome indicators
- Impact indicators
- Reporting framework
- Sustainability plan
- Risk-management framework

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9. CSR SUPPORT FOR EDUCATIONAL INSTITUTIONS

NCIE may facilitate eligible colleges, universities and educational institutions in developing CSR proposals for initiatives such as:

- Innovation Centres
- Incubation Centres
- Innovation Laboratories
- Entrepreneurship Development Cells
- Student Innovation Programmes
- AI & Digital Innovation Labs
- Startup Development Programmes
- Prototype Development Facilities
- Entrepreneurship Training
- Faculty Development
- Industry–Academia Engagement
- Skill Development Facilities

10. INDICATIVE INSTITUTIONAL CSR SUPPORT

Depending on project scale, eligibility and the priorities of the concerned CSR organisation, institutional project requirements may be developed within an indicative range of:

₹5 LAKH – ₹25 LAKH

Potential use areas may include:

- Infrastructure
- Technology
- Equipment
- Training
- Innovation activities
- Startup support
- Faculty development
- Mentorship
- Programme delivery
- Monitoring and impact assessment

The stated range represents an **indicative project requirement framework** and does not constitute a guaranteed CSR grant or funding commitment.

11. STUDENT INNOVATION & STARTUP CSR SUPPORT

CSR-supported innovation programmes may include:

- Student innovation challenges
- Prototype development
- Proof-of-concept support
- Mentoring
- Entrepreneurship training
- Startup validation
- Incubation support
- Technology development

For selected eligible startup initiatives, programme proposals may include **indicative seed-support requirements up to ₹5 lakh per startup**, subject to applicable project guidelines, evaluation, selection, resource availability and approval of the concerned CSR or funding organisation.

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12. CSR–ACADEMIA–INDUSTRY CONVERGENCE

NCIE may facilitate a collaborative model involving:

CSR ORGANISATION

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NCIE

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COLLEGE / UNIVERSITY

↓

STUDENTS & FACULTY

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INNOVATION / ENTREPRENEURSHIP PROGRAMME

↓

INDUSTRY / MENTOR / INCUBATION SUPPORT

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MEASURABLE OUTCOMES

This model is intended to combine corporate resources with institutional infrastructure and technical expertise.

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13. CSR & GOVERNMENT PROGRAMME CONVERGENCE

Where appropriate and legally permissible, NCIE may facilitate complementary linkages among:

- CSR organisations
- Educational institutions
- Government programmes
- Public-sector institutions
- Industry
- Innovation ecosystem organisations

Any Government association shall be represented only where supported by appropriate **official approval, programme documentation, agreement or sanction.**

CSR participation shall not automatically imply Government approval or Government funding.

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14. CSR PARTNER CONTRIBUTIONS

Depending on the project, CSR partners may contribute:

Financial Support

Approved project funding.

Technology Support

Equipment, software, tools or digital infrastructure.

Knowledge Support

Experts, trainers and technical resources.

Mentorship

Industry, entrepreneurship and technology mentors.

Infrastructure

Training, innovation or incubation facilities.

Scholarship Support

Eligible educational or student-support initiatives.

In-Kind Contributions

Equipment, resources, services or other approved non-cash support.

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15. NCIE'S ROLE IN CSR PROJECTS

Subject to the specific agreement, NCIE may facilitate:

- Need assessment
- Project conceptualisation
- Proposal development
- Institutional coordination
- Beneficiary mobilisation
- Programme design
- Trainer and mentor coordination
- Implementation support
- Digital programme management
- Monitoring
- Documentation
- Reporting
- Outcome and impact assessment

NCIE's exact responsibilities shall be defined in the applicable CSR project agreement.

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16. ROLE OF THE CSR PARTNER

Depending on the approved project, the CSR organisation may:

- Review and approve the project
- Define funding conditions
- Provide financial or technical resources
- Participate in governance or review mechanisms
- Monitor implementation
- Review utilisation
- Participate in impact assessment
- Provide expert or industry support

The CSR organisation shall retain its independent authority over its CSR approval and funding decisions.

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17. ROLE OF THE PARTICIPATING INSTITUTION

Participating educational institutions may support:

- Student mobilisation
 - Faculty coordination
 - Venue and infrastructure
 - Institutional programme implementation
 - Attendance
 - Beneficiary verification
 - Institutional reporting
 - Programme monitoring
 - Sustainability of supported infrastructure
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18. CSR DUE DILIGENCE FRAMEWORK

CSR partnerships may be subject to appropriate due diligence covering:

- Legal status
- Organisational documentation
- Governance
- Financial records
- Programme experience
- Compliance status
- Implementation capability
- Institutional credibility
- Project feasibility
- Monitoring capability

The scope of due diligence may vary according to project size and the requirements of the concerned corporate organisation.

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19. CSR FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT

CSR project funds shall be managed according to applicable:

- Approved budgets
- Funding agreements
- Financial controls
- Accounting procedures
- Utilisation conditions
- Procurement procedures

- Supporting-document requirements
- Reporting obligations

Project expenditure should be traceable to approved project activities.

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20. PROJECT BUDGETING

CSR project budgets may include:

- Human resources
- Training
- Technology
- Equipment
- Programme materials
- Institutional infrastructure
- Beneficiary support
- Travel and field activities
- Digital systems
- Monitoring
- Evaluation
- Documentation
- Other approved programme costs

Budgets should be linked to the proposed programme outputs and outcomes.

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21. MONITORING & EVALUATION

CSR projects may be monitored using:

Input Indicators

- Funds allocated
- Personnel deployed
- Technology and infrastructure provided

Output Indicators

- Beneficiaries reached

- Participants trained
- Institutions supported
- Sessions conducted
- Projects developed

Outcome Indicators

- Skills developed
- Innovation capability improved
- Entrepreneurship readiness
- Institutional capacity strengthened

Impact Indicators

- Sustainable innovation ecosystems
- Startup progression
- Employment or enterprise-related outcomes where verifiable
- Social and economic impact

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22. CSR REPORTING MECHANISM

Reporting may include:

- Monthly progress reports
- Quarterly reports
- Financial utilisation reports
- Beneficiary reports
- Activity documentation
- Output and outcome reports
- Project completion report
- Impact assessment report

The reporting schedule shall be determined in the applicable project agreement.

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23. UTILISATION & DOCUMENTATION

Where required, NCIE may maintain:

- Funding records
- Expenditure records
- Invoices and bills
- Beneficiary records
- Attendance
- Programme reports
- Procurement records
- Asset records
- Utilisation statements
- Supporting evidence

Documentation requirements may vary according to the funding agreement and applicable legal requirements.

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24. IMPACT ASSESSMENT

CSR programme impact may be assessed based on:

- Beneficiary reach
- Skills developed
- Student outcomes
- Innovation outputs
- Startup progression
- Institutional development
- Faculty capacity
- Industry engagement
- Programme sustainability
- Social and economic outcomes

For large or qualifying programmes, impact assessment may be undertaken independently where required by applicable law, corporate policy or programme terms.

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25. CSR PROJECT GOVERNANCE

Larger CSR projects may establish an appropriate governance structure such as:

CSR PARTNER / AUTHORISED REPRESENTATIVE**NCIE PROGRAMME MANAGEMENT****PARTNER INSTITUTION****PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION TEAM****MONITORING & REPORTING FUNCTION**

Specific roles shall be established through the project agreement.

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26. TRANSPARENCY & ACCOUNTABILITY

NCIE shall seek to maintain:

- Clear project objectives
- Defined budgets
- Written agreements
- Programme records
- Financial documentation
- Beneficiary records
- Monitoring systems
- Outcome reporting
- Appropriate audit and verification

CSR funding shall not be represented as approved until supported by formal corporate approval or other applicable documentation.

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27. BRANDING & COMMUNICATION

Use of a CSR partner's:

- Name
- Logo
- Trademark
- Corporate identity
- Funding claim

- Sponsorship claim

shall be subject to applicable permissions and agreement terms.

NCIE shall not describe a corporate organisation as a CSR partner unless an appropriate partnership, approval or agreement exists.

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28. CONFLICT OF INTEREST

NCIE personnel, consultants, evaluators and participating stakeholders should disclose relevant conflicts of interest in:

- Procurement
- Vendor selection
- Beneficiary selection
- Startup selection
- Funding decisions
- Project evaluation

Appropriate measures should be taken to preserve fairness and objectivity.

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29. DATA & BENEFICIARY PROTECTION

CSR projects involving beneficiary data should incorporate appropriate measures for:

- Data collection
- Authorisation
- Privacy
- Confidentiality
- Access control
- Data security
- Responsible information sharing
- Record retention

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30. CSR PROJECT RISK MANAGEMENT

Potential risks may include:

- Funding delays
- Lower beneficiary participation
- Procurement delays
- Technology issues
- Implementation delays
- Compliance issues
- Cost escalation
- Programme-quality issues

Each major project may maintain appropriate mitigation measures.

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31. SUSTAINABILITY FRAMEWORK

CSR-supported initiatives should seek to generate value beyond the initial funding period.

Sustainability measures may include:

- Institutional ownership
- Faculty capacity building
- Reusable digital infrastructure
- Train-the-trainer models
- Shared institutional resources
- Long-term industry partnerships
- Innovation ecosystems
- Continued entrepreneurship programmes

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32. CSR PARTNERSHIP LIFECYCLE

PARTNER IDENTIFICATION

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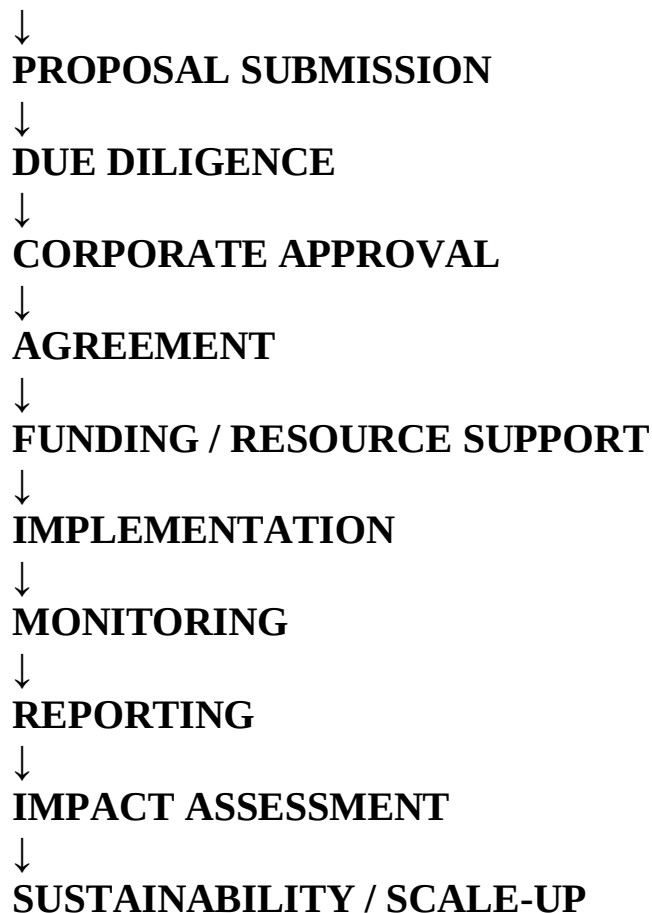
CSR PRIORITY MAPPING

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NEED ASSESSMENT

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PROJECT DESIGN



33. CSR PARTNERSHIP PERFORMANCE INDICATORS

Indicative KPIs may include:

- CSR partners engaged
- CSR proposals submitted
- Projects approved
- Resources mobilised
- Institutions supported
- Students reached
- Participants trained
- Innovation projects developed
- Faculty trained
- Startups supported
- Mentorship engagements
- Programme completion rate
- Outcome achievement rate
- Impact indicators

34. CSR ECOSYSTEM MODEL

CORPORATES & CSR FOUNDATIONS



NCIE



COLLEGES & UNIVERSITIES



STUDENTS & YOUTH



INNOVATORS & STARTUPS



INDUSTRY & MENTORS



INCUBATORS & ACCELERATORS



COMMUNITIES

This ecosystem is intended to transform CSR resources into **structured educational, innovation, entrepreneurship and institutional-development outcomes**.

35. STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT

Eligible CSR programmes may support NCIE's broader thematic priorities relating to:

- Education
- Innovation
- Entrepreneurship
- Skill development
- Artificial Intelligence and technology
- Youth empowerment
- Institutional development
- Employment and enterprise readiness
- Inclusive development

Where relevant, these interventions may contribute within NCIE's organisational mandate to the broader national aspiration of **Viksit Bharat @2047**.

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36. CSR PARTNERSHIP STATEMENT

The NCIE CSR Partnership Framework seeks to establish a transparent, accountable and outcome-oriented mechanism for collaboration with eligible corporate and CSR organisations in support of education, innovation, entrepreneurship, skills, technology, youth development and institutional capacity building.

All CSR funding and support shall remain subject to applicable legal requirements, corporate CSR policies, project eligibility, due diligence, formal approval, funding availability and the terms of the relevant agreement. No proposed CSR contribution shall be represented as confirmed funding unless supported by appropriate documentary evidence.

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37. NCIE CSR IMPACT PATHWAY

IDENTIFY

Recognise beneficiary and institutional needs.

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PARTNER

Engage suitable CSR organisations.

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INVEST

Mobilise approved financial, technical and institutional resources.



IMPLEMENT

Deliver structured programmes.



MEASURE

Track outputs and outcomes.



IMPACT

Generate sustainable educational, innovation, entrepreneurship and social value.

**CSR → INNOVATION → SKILLS → ENTREPRENEURSHIP →
INSTITUTIONAL CAPACITY → SUSTAINABLE IMPACT**